

Dangerous PLAY

The squabbling between Bhaichung Bhutia and Mohun Bagan may harm the Indian team that has to prepare for the Asian Cup

By Elora Sen

With superstars being few and far between in Indian football, it's hardly surprising that not too many match Bhaichung Bhutia's stature. The Indian captain who recently became the first to play 100 international matches though has recently been in the news not for his on-field exploits, but rather for different reasons off it. And the sport's ruling body, the All-India Football Federation (AIFF), has done its two bits, adding fuel to the fire.

Even as Indian football has seen a bit of a rise after winning the Nehru Cup—India are now 138 on the FIFA rankings list, up 11 positions from last month—what has led to more noise is that Bhutia was hauled up by Mohun Bagan so severely that he left the club in a huff vowing never to return. The star has since signed up for East Bengal to play the I-League. This when there is no certainty on whether this is part of AIFF's rules. Can a player suspended by his club on disciplinary grounds switch teams? The AIFF says the matter is still under arbitration and Bagan is up in arms, saying legal recourse awaits it. For his part, Bhutia says he was given "permission" by the AIFF arbitrator to play for any team of his choice until the final decision was taken.

Once again, Indian football is scoring what seems like an own goal by



mishandling the dispute between its most famous player and one of its oldest clubs. At a time when the world ruling body FIFA has tried to give Indian football a new boost, the AIFF has only been able to send out mixed messages. The much-touted I-League has become the most important event in AIFF's calendar, and the once popular AIFF tournaments like the IFA Shield, Scissors Cup, Rovers Cup, Durand Cup, Bordoloi Cup and even the national championship, the Santosh Trophy, have taken a backseat. Asked whether this is really helping Indian football, AIFF general secretary, Alberto Colaco said: "The I-League has to be the most important football tournament in the

AIFF football calendar. The success of the national team is directly dependent on having a very good professional football league. If you see Japan, until they launched the J-league, the performances of the national team were not good. The AIFF competitions have to be restructured and there has to be a clear division between amateur and professional football."

With many regions of interest and a huge talent pool, the results around Indian football remain poor. For a long time, the lack of sponsors and funds was AIFF's favourite whipping-horse. In 2005, Zee Sports signed a 10-year deal to televise and market domestic football worth around Rs 273 crore.